

**LISTENING
#30****Teacher's Guide****SCRIPT: DOG INTELLIGENCE**

Presenter: So, given what we've learned about the dog's evolutionary history, how might your dog's genetics play into its intelligence and behavior? Here to tell us a bit about that is Dr. Stanley Coren. Dr. Coren, welcome to Quirks & Quarks.

Dr. Coren: Glad to be here.

Presenter: Well, when you saw this sort of genetic mapping that was happening, what went through your mind about how that relates to the intelligence of dogs?

Dr. Coren: Now you've got to remember there's three kinds of canine intelligence. One is instinctive intelligence, which is what the dog was bred to do. So herding dogs herd, and guarding dogs guard, and retrievers retrieve — that sort of thing. The next is adaptive intelligence. That's what a dog can learn to do for himself. The other form is what we call working and obedience intelligence, which is the equivalent of school learning.

So, if you look at that working obedience intelligence, you tend to find out that certain dogs which have particular characteristics tend not to do so well, and others tend to do very well.

So the oldest of the dog breeds are the hounds. The hounds were meant to be sort of independent hunters. And their job was to run that prey down without very much guidance from human beings. Well, that makes them lousy students.

On the other hand, the retrievers, which are rather late inventions, were designed to sort of wait for our cue. You know, don't scare the ducks, don't scare the game, and sit quietly. Pay attention to me, and I'll tell you when you have to run out retrieve this. And so those dogs make wonderful students.

Presenter: So what is it about dogs that makes them so malleable?

Dr. Coren: We've been selectively doing this seat-of-the-pants kind of behavior genetics for dogs for at least 14,000 years. It was the first domesticated species. So we were building something which would be a co-worker with us, but we also wanted something which would interact with the kids and that sort of thing. And so we began to build these dogs so that not only did they respond to us, but they began to read us, and we could begin to read them.

So, take a very simple task. If I point to something, my dog recognizes that that is a communication signal and he looks in that direction. But if I do that for a wolf, even if that wolf has been reared since puppyhood in a human surrounding, the wolf doesn't look in the direction I point, but he looks at my hand.

So, one of the things which we've been doing is we have been breeding dogs and selecting them so that they respond to us, our signals, and our moods. And the flip side is that we've been breeding dogs so that we can read their moods. That builds you a companion. If you're sharing in this sort of empathetic way, it's no longer, you know, just an animal, it's a friend.

Presenter: Dr. Coren, thank you very much for your time.

Dr. Coren: Thanks for having me.

Answer Key

Comprehension Activity

1. Instinctive intelligence
2. b) What the dog can learn for itself
3. c) Hounds
4. b) They were bred to hunt independently
5. b) They wait for human cues and follow instructions
6. At least 14,000 years
7. Pointing at something and having the dog look in that direction
8. c) It looks at the person's hand

Reading Comprehension

1. They can interpret human gestures such as pointing, directing, and eye movements.
2. They can detect subtle changes in human facial expressions and vocal tones.
3. They were bred for independent work.
4. It helped develop dogs that were cooperative, attentive, and responsive to human social signals.
5. It allows dogs to sense human emotions and adjust their behavior, strengthening the bond.

Idioms & Vocabulary

“Seat-of-the-pants” = based on intuition rather than careful planning.

Dr. Coren refers to “seat-of-the-pants kind of behavior genetics.”

“Flip side” = the opposite or contrasting aspect of something.

He says: “And the flip side is that we’ve been breeding dogs so that we can read their moods.”

“Feedback loop” = a process where results reinforce the original cause, creating continuous effects.